



Rain, t-storm 59/45 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny, windy 52/34 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, DECEMBER 31, 2024 • \$4

Twelve months when a presidency unraveled

How economic pain, a crisis in Iran and a primary foe sank Carter

BY DAN BALZ

It was a year that shattered a presidency.

For Jimmy Carter, the 12 months that culminated in the 1980 general election were marked by economic turmoil, international humiliation and a political challenge from the most recognizable family name in the Democratic Party. Together, they would drive Carter from office, leaving a punctuation mark on his one-term presidency that only the passage of time, and his remarkable post-presidency, have helped to change.

What happened in those months — November 1979 to November 1980 — reverberated long after Carter left office. Ronald Reagan's victory in the presidential race ushered in a conservative era that reshaped American politics for a generation. The primary challenge to Carter from Sen. Edward M. Kennedy (D-Massachusetts) left the Democratic Party divided and contributed to wilderness years that lasted a decade.

Internationally, the year-long Iranian hostage crisis defined a hostile relationship between the two countries that continues to the present day, despite the 2015 diplomatic agreement designed to block Iran's nuclear ambitions, a pact from which the United States withdrew under President Donald Trump.

In the opening days of November
SEE CARTER ON A4



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

In remembrance

Nelle Ariail, a longtime friend of Jimmy Carter, holds her dog, Lizzie, while lighting a candle for the former president during a prayer service at Maranatha Baptist Church in Plains, Georgia.

Home-building: Habitat for Humanity helped define a legacy. A5

Political partners: Biden and Carter had a long friendship. A6

Celebrity: Carter didn't work to retain his cultural currency. C1

Carter services coming to a capital in transition

Mourning to overlap with turmoil in House, change in administration

BY AZI PAYBARAH

The death of former president Jimmy Carter touched off an American mourning ritual that requires quickly coordinating a sprawling group of federal officials, local partners and law enforcement, as well as elected leaders from across the political spectrum.

Services to honor Carter will begin Jan. 4 in his home state of Georgia and conclude Jan. 9 with a state funeral at Washington National Cathedral, where President Joe Biden will deliver the eulogy. Carter will lie in state in the Ro-

tunda of the U.S. Capitol for three days, which will give members of Congress and everyday Americans the opportunity to pay their respects.

The events require a complicated choreography of protocol, ceremony and security at which official Washington excels, but the timing of Carter's funeral presents some particular challenges. The former president died Sunday at the age of 100.

The tributes to Carter come after the New Year's Day holiday and as Washington is experiencing a political transition, with Biden preparing to hand power to President-elect Donald Trump. Separately, a fractured House Republican majority will try to elect a speaker on Jan. 3, a process that previously took the GOP dozens of rounds of votes spread over several days of public feuding.

SEE MOURNING ON A5

In tiny Maldives, big powers vie for sway

Effort to oust pro-China leader offers view into India's struggles in Asia

BY GERRY SHIH
AND SIDDHARTHA ROY

MALE, MALDIVES — In late 2023, Mohamed Muizzu became a problem for India.

In fiery speeches, the newly elected president of the Maldives pledged to expel Indian troops stationed in his island nation. He was instead friendly with China, India's regional rival, and sought to sign a military assistance pact with Beijing. By January 2024, agents working at the behest of India's intelligence agency, the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW), began quietly discussing with Maldivian opposition leaders the possibility of removing Muizzu, according to people involved in the discussions. And within weeks, a plan emerged.

In an internal document titled "Democratic Renewal Initiative" and obtained by The Washington Post, Maldivian opposition politicians proposed bribing 40 members of parliament, including those from Muizzu's own party, to vote to impeach him. The document also proposed paying 10 senior army and police officers and three powerful criminal gangs to ensure Muizzu's removal. To pay off the various parties, the conspirators sought \$7 million Maldivian rufiyaa, or \$6 million, and according to two Maldivian officials, it would be sought from India.

After months of secret talks, the plotters failed to gather enough votes to impeach Muizzu, and India did not pursue or finance an attempt to oust him.

Still, the Maldivian plot and its backstory offer a rare view into the much broader, often shadowy struggle between India and China for influence over a strategic swath of Asia and its surrounding waters. This competition has unfolded particularly in the smaller nations around the Indian Ocean, where the continent's two largest powers have offered generous loans, infrastructure projects and political support — both public and covert — to bolster their preferred politicians.

For New Delhi, the growing rivalry with China has sharpened a long-standing foreign policy dilemma. For decades, India has provided humanitarian assistance and supported secular, democratic movements across

SEE MALDIVES ON A12

THE CONCUSSION FILES



PHOTOS BY DUSTIN CHAMBERS FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Fighting ex-players for every cent

It took five years, three doctor's visits, two federal lawsuits and countless emails with his lawyers, but Reggie Brown finally got word in February: He officially had dementia. Which meant, he believed, it was time for the NFL to pay up.

Brown, 64, had been fighting for years to get paid by the landmark NFL concussion settlement, which promised to compensate every former player with dementia or a brain disease linked to head trauma. Under the rules of the settlement, Brown's lawyers told him, his diagnosis entitled him to about \$200,000.

All that stood between him and a check was BrownGreer, the independent administrative firm that examines all claims. He had heard stories about the firm taking months, even years, to review claims, but he hoped his would move quickly. After all, his diagnosis had come from a board-certified settlement doctor who had been vetted by BrownGreer and lawyers for the NFL.

Then, in July, Brown received an email from the firm. It had

Using medical records and social media, law firm BrownGreer delays and denies scores of claims in NFL settlement

BY WILL HOBSON
IN ELLENWOOD, GA.



"It feels like these people are really trying to jam me up," said Reggie Brown, a former NFL running back who was diagnosed with dementia and has sought compensation through the league's concussion settlement.

reviewed his tax returns and scoured his social media activity, and it wanted to know:

If Brown had dementia, how had he managed to work part-time, earning about \$30,000 annually the past five years?

Why did he claim online he worked as a motivational speaker?

And what about the Facebook posts that showed him attending his daughter's graduate school graduation, traveling with his wife and going to the gym?

"It feels like these people are really trying to jam me up," Brown, a former running back for the Atlanta Falcons and Philadelphia Eagles, said in a recent interview in his home outside Atlanta.

When lawyers for the NFL and thousands of former players struck the historic settlement a decade ago, they entrusted the crucial role of managing it to BrownGreer, one of the most experienced firms in the country focused on settlement administration. And BrownGreer's founding partner, Orran Brown Sr.,

SEE CONCUSSIONS ON A7

Trump endorses Johnson reelection

SPEAKER VOTE RESTS ON SLIM MAJORITY

At least one in GOP has pledged to oppose him

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR,
MARIANA ALFARO
AND MERYL KORNFELD

President-elect Donald Trump gave House Republican lawmakers a directive on Monday, days before what is expected to become an embattled speakership fight: Support Mike Johnson's reelection.

In a lengthy post on his social media platform, Truth Social, Trump argued that Republicans should "NOT BLOW THIS GREAT OPPORTUNITY WHICH WE HAVE BEEN GIVEN" by voters to immediately govern, which would require Johnson (R-Louisiana) to be swiftly re-elected as House speaker on Friday.

"Speaker Mike Johnson is a good, hard working, religious man. He will do the right thing, and we will continue to WIN. Mike has my Complete & Total Endorsement," Trump wrote.

Johnson responded on social media. "Thank you, President Trump! I'm honored and humbled by your support, as always," he said, shortly after blasting out Trump's endorsement via a press release. "Together, we will quickly deliver on your America First agenda and usher in the new golden age of America. The American people demand and deserve that we waste no time. Let's get to work!"

Multibillionaire Elon Musk, who has become an influential ally of Trump's, replied to Johnson's post, saying the speaker also has his "full support." Musk issued that endorsement just weeks after expressing doubts about Johnson's handling of legislation to fund the government.

House Republicans have said for weeks that Trump would have the final say on whether Johnson keeps the gavel or is replaced. The president-elect's endorsement is significant as it signals to House Republicans to stay in line and back Johnson, who began losing support from several corners of the GOP conference during negotiations on how to fund

SEE JOHNSON ON A9

IN THE NEWS

Treasury hack The department said a China-backed agent gained access to government workstations and unclassified documents. A15

A year in review Post reporters take a step back and revisit some of the stories in the Washington region that delighted, entertained or moved us in 2024. B1

THE NATION Senior citizens owe billions in student loan debt, and some are asking for help. A3
Donald Trump lost an appeal in the defamation and sexual abuse case from E. Jean Carroll. A3

THE WORLD A debate on genital cutting in Gambia has led to talk about women's sexual pleasure. A10
The WHO chief called for the release of a Gaza doctor detained in a hospital raid. A11

THE ECONOMY Pending home sales rose for the fourth month in a row in November, signaling a strengthening housing market. A14
The probe of an airliner crash in South Korea is likely to focus on possible bird strikes and a runway barrier. A14

THE REGION A patient at Maryland's psychiatric hospital was brutally beaten by two other patients this month, a state police investigator wrote. B1
The U.S. attorney for D.C., Matthew M. Graves, said he will resign before Donald Trump takes office. B1

STYLE People are spending thousands of dollars on surgical procedures to change their eye color, but doctors disagree on whether the process is safe. C1
HEALTH & SCIENCE The section is taking a break this week. It will return on Jan. 7.

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COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A16
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